

Chapter 169-4

Liang Shi said, "I don't know why I was so stubborn as a child either. Actually, thinking about it now, it was just a matter of one sentence."

"Even if you were asked to do it now, you still wouldn't." Xu Qingzhu said with certainty. "Because that's just who Liang Shi is."

"That's not true." Liang Shi said, "When you were kidnapped by Chen Liuying before, I was also quite..."

"No, no, no." Xu Qingzhu said, "That's because the person who was kidnapped was me. But if it were you, you definitely wouldn't have done that."

Liang Shi: "..."

Having been struck at a vital point, Liang Shi was momentarily speechless.

After a moment, Liang Shi finally smiled and said, "A lot of people used to say that the rigid are easily broken. Over the years, I've actually been tempering my character. I think I can bend and stretch pretty well now. Grandma once told me that the most valuable thing a person can have is self-awareness."

"Not in the way it's used to insult people nowadays. What she meant was, only you truly understand what kind of person you are. No matter what others say about you, those thousands of versions aren't the real you. So it doesn't matter what you say on the surface. You can be two-faced, you can flatter and fawn—but you have to know that it's wrong. That's enough."

On the late night when she thought of her grandmother, Liang Shi also had a dream. She dreamed of taking her grandparents to the seaside, fulfilling their wish.

When she woke up, tears had soaked half her pillow. Xu Qingzhu was right beside her, watching her, her heart aching terribly.

Xu Qingzhu handed her tissues, but that wasn't enough. On a whim, she took her to the outskirts of the city to see the ocean.

These days were peaceful and warm for Liang Shi.

Every day was radiant and worth commemorating.

This New Year was spent at the Su family's home.

Since Xu Qingzhu was going to the Su family's, she brought Sheng Linlang and the others along.

Xu Guangyao had already stepped down from his decision-making position at the company. For nearly half a year, he had been traveling everywhere with Sheng Linlang. After returning to Haizhou, he had picked up his old profession again, designed a whole set, and spent every day hammering away at home, planning to make a set of jewelry.

He said it was to make up for the regret of his hasty marriage to Sheng Linlang back then.

This New Year was much livelier than usual.

Xu Qingzhu also announced her pregnancy during the reunion dinner.

Everyone was shocked, but more than that, they were happy.

So that evening, Su Zhe and Xu Guangyao got completely drunk, even to the point of calling each other brothers.

When Su Zhe drank too much, he had no filter. He started complaining about Sheng Linlang's parents. Even though his wife slapped his back several times, he didn't get the hint. But then he changed the subject: "Those two weren't good people, but strangely, the children they raised all turned out pretty well. If that boy Sheng Qinglin were still alive, he would have also..."

"Smack—" Mrs. Su slapped Su Zhe on the back of his neck. The pain made Su Zhe swallow all his words and just argue with her: "Why did you hit me?!"

Mrs. Su said matter-of-factly, "There was a mosquito."

Everyone: "...?"

But at least it stopped Su Zhe from continuing.

However, everyone present had still heard the name Sheng Qinglin, and they all fell silent.

Especially Sheng Linlang and Su Yao.

Their gazes met in the air, each seeing the other's reddened eyes.

Xu Qingzhu walked over and asked Sheng Linlang, "When... are we going to pay respects to my father?"

Sheng Linlang was stunned, realizing that she had changed how she addressed things.

Xu Qingzhu bit her lower lip. She decided that she had to do this eventually, so she steeled her heart and called out, "Auntie."

Sheng Linlang's eyes immediately welled up with tears. She smiled and responded, then said, "The fifth day of the new year."

Regarding Xu Qingzhu changing her form of address back, Sheng Linlang and Xu Guangyao felt a bit sad, but they didn't say anything.

She should have been calling them aunt and uncle all along.

Xu Guangyao had hinted at this twice before, but Xu Qingzhu had glossed over it each time.

On this reunion night, Xu Qingzhu finally changed how she addressed them.

Afterward, Sheng Linlang even asked if she wanted to change her name. Xu Qingzhu shook her head. "I've been using it for so many years now. There's no need to change it. Everyone knows what I'm called. Let's wait for my child—I'll change it back for her in the future."

From now on, this family would still bear the Sheng surname. That wasn't a problem.

Actually, it was just a name—a label, really.

But sometimes when the burden on one's shoulders grew heavier and the bonds grew stronger, surnames would feel especially important.

After the reunion dinner, when they left the Su family's home, traffic flowed on the roads like shuttles. The city was bright as day, and the whole world felt like a huge, gentle cocoon wrapping them inside.

After leaving the bustle behind, people would feel a great sense of loss.

No matter where you walked, it felt lonely.

Liang Shi turned on the car stereo. It happened to be "Flock of Lonely Birds," the song Qi Jiao had recommended to Chen Mian.

The singer's voice was very gentle, with a hint of huskiness—the classic voice for singing love songs.

"What lies at the end of the universe

Have you ever been there

We made wishes under the same sky

What did you wish for back then

I was secretly watching you

And forgot to even make a wish

...

Your life isn't that bad

You still have me entangled with you

Even lonely birds can find companionship

...

I will remember you

And if I forget, I'll let the lonely bird carry my wishes to you

Even if we're destined to part

I'm still willing to be with you

..."

Xu Qingzhu leaned against the car seat, softly humming along.

Liang Shi suddenly spoke. "This is a song that Qi Jiao and Chen Mian really liked."

"I really like it too." Xu Qingzhu's gaze shifted to the side. Along Liang Shi's profile, she could see the bustling scene outside.

The entire city was immersed in festivity, with fireworks blooming in the sky.

Liang Shi said, "I fell in love with it after listening to it once."

Just then, the song was reaching its end. Xu Qingzhu suddenly asked, "Liang Shi, are you lonely?"

Liang Shi was startled. "Huh?"

"Stop playing dumb." Xu Qingzhu said, "Do you want to find your family? Like how Gu Xingyue found her mother, or like how my mom and I reunited. Actually, I think what you said to comfort me back then was right—we're not at an age where we need parents anymore. We can choose not to have them and still live brilliant lives. But at times like this, I often feel like you're lonely."

Liang Shi: "..."

There were moments when she did feel this way.

Even when surrounded by crowds of people, nowhere felt like home.

It was a bit better now—she knew she had Xu Qingzhu, had their little home.

This feeling was especially strong when she was separated from Xu Qingzhu. When she had gone to stay at Zhao Xuning's place, sometimes she couldn't sleep at night and would gaze at the lights of countless homes, giving rise to an unrealistic fantasy.

In this vast city, was there a light that shone just for her?

Was there someone waiting for her to come home?

Was there someone who would treat her like a child no matter how old she got?

This kind of emotional need, when absent since childhood, was actually very real. But people often hid this need away, as if exposing even a little of it was a sign of weakness.

As time passed, this longing would be buried deeper and deeper.

Yes, this kind of emotion wasn't necessary at their age. But if they had it, it would truly be the icing on the cake.